

A Semester in Auckland

Exploring beyond my major, connecting with local life

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2026 Semester One Visiting Program · OAL Ambassador for Australia and New Zealand

My semester at a glance

The University of Auckland · Semester One, 2026

Four courses

Two in Computer Science, one in Astronomy, and one in New Zealand Music History.

Two public performances

AUSC Student Choir
ANZAC performance and end-of-semester concert.

Two ambassador roles

CUHK-Shenzhen Study Abroad Ambassador
Auckland Study Abroad Instagram Ambassador



Exploring both islands

Weekends around Auckland

Two weeks on the South Island at mid-semester
North Island by train after exams, then a winter return to the South Island

Personal experience from my 2026 sharing report. All photos supplied by me.

Why I chose Auckland

The destination shaped what I could do with the semester

Room to explore

Computer Science and Music alongside Physics.

City life and nature

Studying in central Auckland, with opportunities to explore outdoors.

An attractive cost for me

Affordability was part of my decision.



Check required courses, graduation plans and personal finances.

Preparing to go

Several things move forward in parallel after nomination

01 Courses and credit

Check the teaching term.
Ask about prerequisite waivers.
Download syllabuses.
Seek home-university pre-approval.
Have backup courses.

02 Admission

Apply to Auckland.
Follow your offer.
Check visa requirements.
Read insurance terms.

03 Housing and travel

Apply for housing.
Check move-in dates.
Book flights and transfers.
Rideshare / SuperShuttle
Ask about orientation SIM cards.
Be connected on arrival.

04 Home university

Confirm enrolment procedures.
Arrange housing and storage.
Check fees and scholarships.
Read OAL updates.

Course pre-approval and final credit transfer are separate steps.

Waivers, early check-in and orientation SIM cards depend on the course and current arrangements.

What does a semester cost?

Official reference figures in NZD, not my personal 2026 expenses

Item	Reference cost
2027 semester programme fee	14,688.96
2027 semester insurance	499.50
Accommodation per semester	Approx. 7,000–10,000

Other costs

Flights and visa

Food and everyday purchases

Phone and transport

Travel and unexpected expenses

The programme fee covers up to 60 points, usually four courses, including the student services fee.
My CUHK-Shenzhen programme offered a 10% tuition discount; confirm current terms with OAL.
Visiting students can apply for university self-catered housing. Check deadlines and contracts.

An entrance scholarship may reduce the cost substantially. Check how yours applies.

S1 checked 4 Nov 2026. Discount: my programme experience. Housing range is not a TTT-specific quote.

A Physics student choosing across subjects

Keeping a link to my degree while exploring new interests

2

Computer Science (ME)
Building a foundation for further exploration of CS and AI.

1

Astronomy (ME)
Broadening my academic perspective.

1

NZ Music History (GE)
Exploring local culture and a different approach to GE.

I sought pre-approval for all four courses.
The three non-GE courses were intended to fulfil Physics Major Elective requirements.

ME: Major Elective. GE: General Education. Pre-approval does not guarantee final credit transfer.

My course combination. See S2 for current Auckland course restrictions.

Four courses still take careful planning

My experience: regular assignments, varied assessments and a real workload

Work beyond the timetable

Weekly assignments, reading and revision take time outside class.

Check each assessment scheme

Some courses have must-pass or double-pass requirements.

Music History had varied tasks

Essays and quizzes
Timelines and playlists

Give your ears time to adjust

Local accents and speaking speed become more familiar with practice.

Consider the rhythm of assignments as well as the final exam.

Settling into TTT

Te Tirohanga o te Tōangaroa · My accommodation experience



A single room

My own space to rest and study.

Shared cooking and dining spaces

A place to cook and meet neighbours.

RAs and residence activities

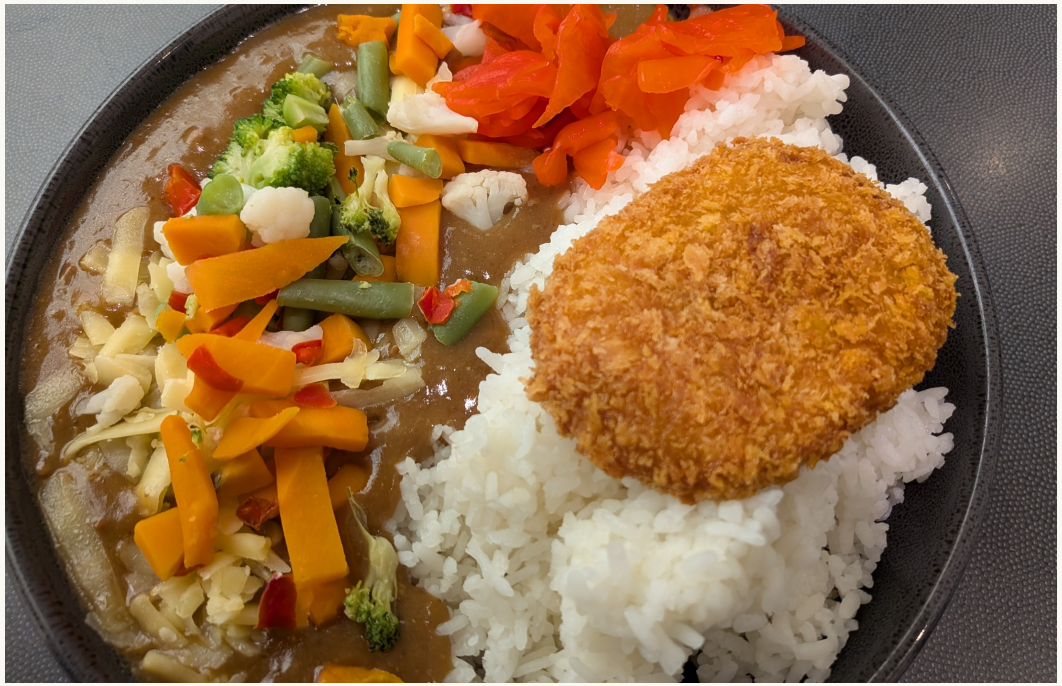
Helped me settle in and make friends.

My walk to class from TTT was about 5–10 minutes. Check your own room type, shared facilities and contract dates.

Personal experience. Apply by the deadline; an accommodation offer does not guarantee your first-choice residence.

Everyday life: food and exercise

Making room for groceries, cooking and sport; visiting-student housing is mainly self-catered



Food

Mix cooking with eating out.
Allow time for grocery shopping.



Hiwa Recreation Centre

Membership is included in university housing fees.
Plenty of facilities and ways to stay active.

My food and Hiwa photos. S4: check bookings and any activity-specific charges separately.

AUSC: rehearsing in English and performing

Auckland University Student Choir





ANZAC Performance

End-of-Semester Concert

My first experience learning music in an all-English setting. Rehearsals and performances also brought local friendships.

Watch: La La Land performance Concert playlist

Personal experience: ANZAC performance and end-of-semester concert. Performance and friendship photos.

Ambassador roles and community connections

Ways to take part in life beyond the classroom

CUHK-Shenzhen ambassador

For Australia and New Zealand.

Auckland Instagram Ambassador

A volunteer role I applied for myself.

Weekly posts on the official Study Abroad account.

A Study Abroad Team field trip

I joined a conservation programme on Motuihe Island, doing environmental volunteer work on the island.



Club Expo as a route into local life

Join clubs that interest you, take part during the semester, and discover opportunities to connect with people and activities in the local community.

My experience; activities vary by semester. The photo shows a gathering with friends.

Exploring the South Island without a car

A mid-semester trip with two friends



Places we visited

Christchurch and Queenstown

Milford Sound and Lake Tekapo

How we travelled

InterCity between towns

AI to help organise ideas

Check official websites
for schedules and connections.

FlexiPass is hours-based. Compare it against individual fares and check eligible services, bookings and extras.

Personal trip; places are not listed in exact travel order. S5: current FlexiPass details.

What I wish I had known before going

A few practical suggestions

Keep backup courses

Term availability, prerequisites, timetable clashes and credit approval can affect your choices.

Find your own balance

Make space for studying, rehearsals and sport, with some time left to simply enjoy being there.

Look for activities actively

Check the university website yourself.

Join clubs at Club Expo and subscribe to their activity emails.

Check sign-ups and meeting arrangements.

Go out together at night, and know who to contact

Stay aware of your surroundings. If something feels wrong, move away and avoid confrontation.

Emergency: 111 Non-emergency Police report: 105 or the online reporting form.
Campus Security: **0800 373 7550**.

Keep in touch with your programme ambassador, who may help connect you with OAL or host-university staff.

Activity channels: personal experience. S6 and S11: Police and campus contacts checked 4 Nov 2026.

What I brought home

A clearer direction in CS and AI

Experience living somewhere unfamiliar

More confidence using English
and making connections.

Thank you!

Q&A 5 minutes

Scan to download slides



Appendix A: arrival and return checklist

For questions and reference after the talk

Before arrival and in your first week

Confirm check-in and airport transport.

Prepare phone access, payment and essentials.

Log into email, Canvas and enrolment systems.

Attend orientation and find support services.
Check current AT student concessions.

Before leaving and returning home

Follow check-out rules and return keys.

Keep transcripts and course outlines.

Apply for final credit transfer.

Confirm enrolment and housing at home.
Complete OAL feedback requirements.

NZTD: air travellers can submit from 24 hours before starting their journey to New Zealand.
Check official rules on food, medicines and outdoor equipment before packing.

S7: New Zealand Traveller Declaration. Follow current programme instructions for other procedures.

Appendix B: what to check when choosing courses

Host-university enrolment and home-university credit recognition are separate

What to check	Where to look or whom to ask
Teaching term and campus	Curriculum Catalogue and course outlines
Prerequisites and restrictions	Course options, course staff or Study Abroad Team
Assessment and workload	Digital Course Outlines; check must-pass requirements
Intended home credit category	Home faculty pre-approval; keep written replies
Final credit recognition	Transcript and formal home-university approval

My case: I sought pre-approval for all four courses. Final recognition depends on the formal decision.

S2: Course options. S3: Assessment of Courses Procedures.

Appendix C: official information

Sources checked 3 Nov 2026; fees, course restrictions and safety contacts rechecked 4 Nov 2026.

S1 Costs and fees: tuition, insurance and accommodation

S2 Course options: availability and restrictions

S3 Assessment of Courses Procedures: threshold requirements

S4 University Accommodation: benefits and Hiwa

S5 InterCity FlexiPass: eligible services and booking

Click a source title to open its website. Confirm current programme terms with OAL and the relevant university offices.

Appendix D: official information

Sources checked 3 Nov 2026; fees, course restrictions and safety contacts rechecked 4 Nov 2026.

S6 University Security: campus help and safety

S7 New Zealand Traveller Declaration: arrival declaration

S8 Immigration New Zealand: Fee Paying Student Visa

S9 University of Auckland: important dates

S10 CUHK-Shenzhen OAL: 2026–2027 programme announcement

S11 New Zealand Police: 111, 105 and online reporting

Click a source title to open its website. Confirm current programme terms with OAL and the relevant university offices.